21 Oct 2026 · nicknamed PHP2Shell

OpenAI says AI helped find a 14-year-old bug in PHP.

PHP runs about 7 in 10 sites we can identify.

What did it find? Swipe →

Subhadeep Ghorai

Why you should care

Built a WordPress site? This is about you.

WordPress runs on PHP. So do about 7 in 10 sites with a known server language.

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Subhadeep Ghorai

W3Techs, 22 Oct 2026

What happened

14 years

Bug sits in PHP unnoticed, per OpenAI

Aug

Calif spots it using AI

Sept

OpenAI finds a fuller version

21 Oct

Early patch. Some governments take sites offline.

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Subhadeep Ghorai

BleepingComputer, Decrypt, Al Jazeera

The idea

A hotel room nobody cleaned.

1 Guest leaves in a rush

2 Cleaner skips the room

3 Next guest finds their things

Room = memory

Cleaner = clean-up

How it works · 1

Servers reuse workers.



One worker answers visitor after visitor. Fast, because nothing restarts.

How it works · 2

Request crashes

↓

Clean-up skipped

↓

Leftover state

↓

Next request uses it

In PHP, leftovers could let an attacker run code: take control of the server.

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The fix, in code

```
// BUG: a crash skips the clean-up
try {
  worker.note = note;
  doWork();            // out of memory
  worker.note = null;
} catch (e) { send(500); }

// FIX: start every request clean
worker.note = null;
```

Real PHP workers (PHP-FPM, mod_php) reuse memory like this. Demo on Wednesday.

What it means for you

- ✔ Run a PHP site? Update to 8.2.35, 8.3.36, 8.4.27 or 8.5.12.
- ✔ On shared hosting? Ask your host if it's patched.
- ✔ Writing a server? Reset state at the start of every request.

Decoder card

A crash left memory dirty. The next visitor walked right in.

Reuse → Crash → Leftovers → Reset

Where in your own project could a crash leave data behind?

WED · WATCH THE LEAK HAPPEN LIVE →